

AI and Automation Practitioner, Level 4

the facts, all in one place' <

Everything you need to know, whether you're thinking of joining the course or putting a member of your team forward.

Qualification	Artificial intelligence (AI) and automation practitioner	Level	Level 4 (equivalent to the first year of a degree)
Approved by	UK Government approved (Skills England). Quality assured by Ofqual	Standard	ST1512, version 2.1 / LARS code 828
Duration	Around 18 months: 15 months of learning, then the end-point assessment	Time commitment	Around 7 hours a week , inside paid working hours
Delivery	Fully online. No in person days	Funding	Up to £18,000 per apprentice. Up to 100% government funded

01 Who it's for

This is an apprenticeship, so the person on the course must be **employed**. It isn't something an individual can enrol on privately. It suits someone already working in or alongside operations, service delivery, customer support, finance or a change team, who has real processes around them that could be improved. They don't need to be, or become, a software developer.

- **What the employer provides**

- A role with **genuine automation or process work to do**, not a hypothetical project
- **Access to the systems** they'll be working with, and permission to build
- A named **workplace mentor**, and around 7 hours a week of their working time

- **Good to know**

- The person on the course needs a **manager above them**, so a business owner can't put themselves forward
- Their employment needs to last for the **whole apprenticeship**, including the end-point assessment
- Existing AI or automation experience is assessed at the start, and the course and funding adjusted to match

Typical job titles for this apprenticeship, from the official standard:

AI integration officer

Automation enablement consultant

Business process support executive

Digital automation specialist

Digital operations technician

Digital productivity consultant

Junior innovation consultant

Process automation analyst

Technology operations coordinator

Workflow solutions assistant

02

Entry requirements

- **Employment and eligibility checks** at the start: residency, employment status, contracted hours and previous qualifications
- **English and maths** in line with apprenticeship funding rules. Most Level 4 apprentices already hold GCSEs. Anyone without them works towards Functional Skills alongside the course, and those hours are on top of the 420
- An **initial assessment** for everyone, plus a digital and accessibility needs check so any adjustments are in place before the first session

There's no formal academic entry requirement beyond the funding rules. Having the right role and a real process to work on matters more than previous qualifications.

The full eligibility rules

These are the government's apprenticeship funding rules for starts from August 2026, as they apply to this apprenticeship.

The apprenticeship

- **Qualification:** Artificial intelligence (AI) and automation practitioner, Level 4

- **Standard reference:** ST1512, version 2.1, LARS code 828
- **Approved for delivery:** 10 December 2025 by Skills England
- **Funding band:** up to £18,000 per apprentice
- **Duration:** typically 18 months in total: 15 months of learning, then the end-point assessment
- **Route:** Digital

Who the apprentice must be

- **Age:** eligibility and funding are based on the apprentice's age on the day they start, and don't change if they have a birthday during the course
- **Employment:** genuinely employed by the employer (or a connected company or charity) for the whole apprenticeship, including the end-point assessment. This is evidenced by a contract of employment or a signed employer declaration
- **Time to complete:** must be able to finish the apprenticeship in the time available. For example, someone whose visa or fixed-term contract ends before the course does is not eligible
- **No minimum time in the job:** there's no requirement to have worked for the employer for a set period first. A new starter can begin on their first day
- **Minimum duration:** the funding rules set a minimum of 8 months for any apprenticeship. This one runs for around 15 months of learning
- **Working hours:** durations are based on at least 30 hours a week, including training. Working fewer hours, or a zero-hours contract, must not be a barrier; the length of the apprenticeship is adjusted to be realistic instead
- **Not eligible if the apprentice:**
 - is self-employed as a sole trader
 - is working under IR35, unless alternative arrangements in the funding rules apply
 - is a shareholder, director or person of significant control with no separate line manager (so a business owner can't put themselves forward)
 - is already on another apprenticeship, a government-funded Skills Bootcamp, or Adult Skills Fund training
- **Residency and right to work:** must have an eligible residency status and the right to work in England. In brief, UK nationals need 3 years' ordinary residence in the UK, Islands or British Overseas Territories before starting; non-UK nationals generally need 3 years' residence in the UK and Islands plus permission to live in the UK that isn't for education only. Separate rules cover EEA and Swiss nationals, Northern Ireland, armed forces, Crown servants and some 16 to 18-year-olds
- **Location:** must spend at least 50% of working hours in England over the whole apprenticeship, including remote and hybrid workers. Apprenticeship funding is devolved, so this apprenticeship isn't available in Scotland, Wales or Northern Ireland
- **English and maths:** apprentices aged 16 to 18 without a Level 2 (GCSE grade 4 or above, or equivalent) must study towards Level 1 or Level 2 English and maths alongside the course. Separate rules apply at 19 to 24

Who the employer must be

- Must genuinely employ the apprentice, so funding can be drawn from their apprenticeship service account or through government co-investment
- Employers in a pooled PAYE scheme can use funds across the organisations in that scheme
- Must pay the apprentice at least the legal minimum wage throughout. The training provider has to check this, and must withdraw the learner if it isn't met

Funding (from August 2026)

- **Apprentice aged 16 to 24, any employer:** 100% government funded, nothing for the employer to pay
- **Apprentice aged 25 or over, non-levy employer:** government pays 95%, the employer pays 5%, up to the funding band
- **Levy-paying employer** (pay bill over £3 million): paid from the levy funds they already contribute
- **From October 2026:** non-levy employers hiring a new apprentice aged 16 to 24 can claim a £2,000 hiring payment, where the apprentice started the job within the last 90 days

What the rules don't allow

- No financial inducements to the apprentice, employer, training provider or assessment organisation for any part of the apprenticeship, including bonuses for starting or completing

Source: [Apprenticeship funding rules, August 2026 to July 2027 \(GOV.UK\)](#) and the [ST1512 standard \(Skills England\)](#). Eligibility is confirmed for each apprentice at enrolment.

03 Time, and how we support them

● The time commitment

- **4 hours a month** in a live online group session
- **Around 5 hours a week** of their own working time, applying it to a real process in the business
- **420 hours** of off-the-job training across the course, the minimum for this standard
- All of it **inside paid working hours**. Not evenings, not weekends

● How we support them

- **One-to-one coaching every month** with a Skills Coach
- A **progress review every eight weeks**
- Learning materials, assignments and resources in one place, on **Aptem**
- Flexible online learning that fits around work

Off-the-job training doesn't mean away from the desk. It means learning something new that relates to the apprenticeship, during working hours. The apprentice records these hours, and they're checked at every review.

What happens, month by month

Thirteen live sessions across 15 months of learning. Each one is applied to the apprentice's own workplace process that month, so the learning lands on a real problem rather than a case study.

Phase 01

Orientation

Months 1 to 2

01

The Practitioner Role, and How AI and Automation Actually Work

The occupation and their own role mapped to the 15 duties. Off-the-job training explained properly, so the log starts in week one.

02

Responsible AI: Law, Ethics and Governance

UK GDPR in automated processes. Automated decision-making rights, and where the law says a human must stay involved.

Phase 02

Discovery

Months 3 to 5

03

Process Discovery, Mapping and Opportunity Analysis

Checkpoint build 1

As-is before to-be. Interviewing the people who do the work and cannot describe how they do it.

04

Data Foundations: Quality, Bias and Error

Profiling a real dataset live. Preparation, conversion, and spotting the errors that break an automation later.

05

Designing for People: Requirements and Human-Centred Design

Checkpoint build 2

Gathering requirements from people who do not know what they want. Writing user stories that survive contact with reality.

Phase 03

Build

Months 6 to 9

06

Working with AI Tools: Prompting and Evaluation

Specifying output precisely. Grounding answers in real documents, and scoring quality rather than judging by impression.

07

Building with Low-Code and No-Code Automation

Checkpoint build 3

Choosing a platform for the organisational context. Building live, including letting things fail on purpose.

08

Connecting Systems: APIs, Integrations and AI Services

Event-driven patterns. Choosing an AI service, and connecting systems that were never designed to talk.

09

Testing, Assurance and Documentation

Designing test cases that find real defects. Assessing viability, and making an honest go-live recommendation.

Phase 04 Embed		Months 10 to 11
10	Adoption, Enablement and Change Resistance treated as information rather than obstruction. Engagement planning, and training your real users.	
11	Governance, Security and Life After Go-Live Governance and accountability. Identifying vulnerabilities, and monitoring what happens once you stop watching.	
Phase 05 Value		Months 12 to 13
12	Proving the Value: Productivity and Cost-Benefit Baseline, measure, attribute. Counting time properly and honestly, including what did not work.	
13	Fairness at Scale and Portfolio Consolidation Algorithmic impact assessment end to end. Workforce equality monitoring, and consolidating the evidence.	
Phase 06 Completion		Months 14 to 15
14	Consolidation and EPA practice No new teaching. A group consolidation session, one-to-one coaching, the portfolio finalised, and practice for the end-point assessment.	
15	Gateway The formal sign-off that they are ready for the end-point assessment, which is then carried out separately by the assessment organisation.	

Checkpoint builds at months 3, 5 and 7 mean something working exists early. A monthly assignment is submitted through Aptem throughout, building into the portfolio.

05 What they finish with

- A **recognised Level 4 qualification**, a national standard rather than a private certificate
- A **working automation live in the business**, documented and handed over
- A **costed report** setting out what it actually saved, measured against a baseline taken at the start
- A **portfolio** of workplace evidence covering all 64 knowledge, skills and behaviours in the standard

06 How it's assessed

The final assessment, called the **end-point assessment**, happens after the gateway sign-off. It's carried out by an independent assessment organisation, not by the training provider or the tutor, and is expected to have two parts:

- A **project report**, with a 30 minute questioning session

- A **portfolio of workplace evidence**, with a 60 minute professional discussion

The assessment organisation for this standard is being appointed. The two part model above is the expected format and the course is built around it, but the final detail is confirmed at enrolment.

07 What it costs the employer

Apprentice under 25

£0

Fully funded

Paid for by the government, whatever the size of the business.

Apprentice 25 or over, no levy

5%

Government pays 95%

The employer contributes the remaining 5%.

Levy payer (wage bill over £3 million)

Levy

Money already paid

Drawn from the levy pot the employer already pays into each month.

Funding for this apprenticeship is up to £18,000. Unspent levy funds expire after 12 months. If a levy payer's pot for the year has run out, the contribution for an apprentice aged 25 or over is 25% rather than 5%. There's no cost to the apprentice in any case.

08 Where it leads

Progression routes recognised on the standard include **data engineer**, **data scientist** (integrated degree) and **AI data specialist**.

Check any of this yourself. The official government record for this apprenticeship is published by Skills England:

skillsengland.education.gov.uk/apprenticeship-standards/st1512

Take the next step

Talk to our team.

Bring one process to a 20 minute call and we'll show you what it looks like mapped onto the course. No commitment, and nothing to prepare.

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Level 4 AI and Automation Practitioner apprenticeship (standard ST1512) · fully online